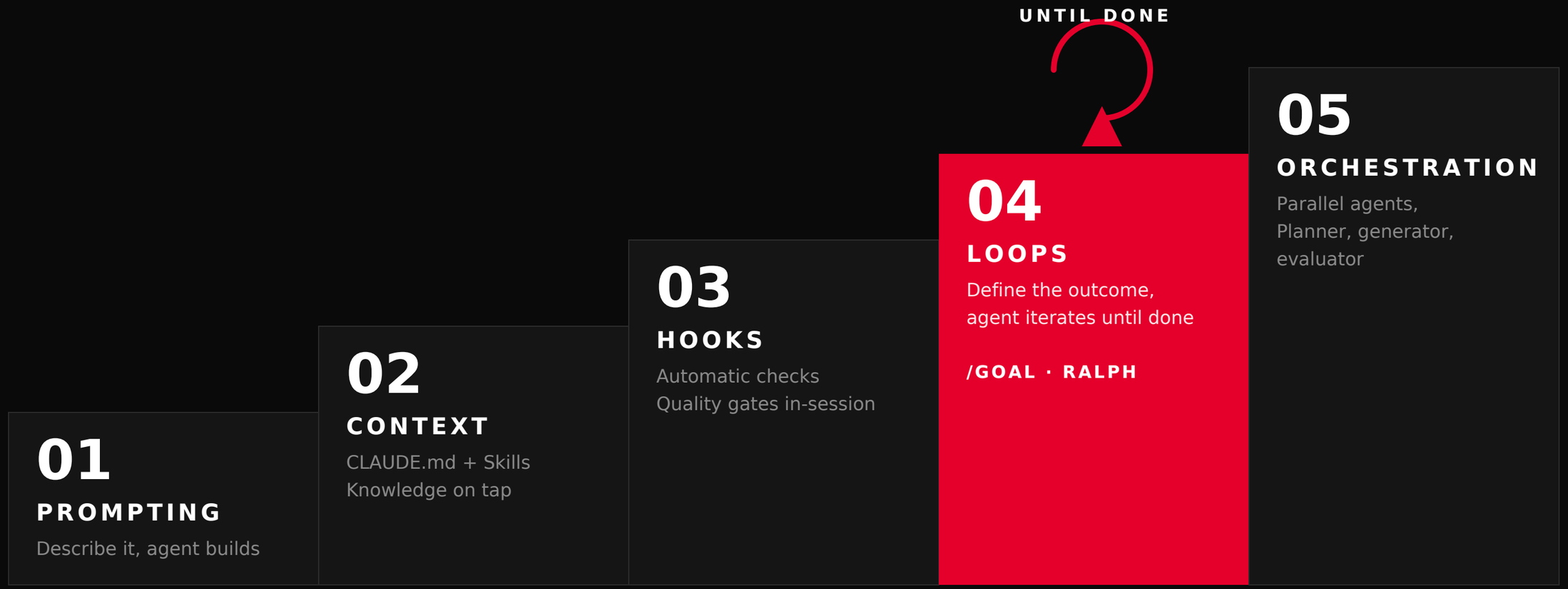
AGENTIC ENGINEERING

From prompt to loop.

Five levels. Each exists because the one below it hit a ceiling.



AGENTIC ENGINEERING

Four shifts to loops.

What changed since the five-level model: from a bash loop to a built-in finish line.

MID 2025

01

RALPH LOOP

Agent in a bash loop. Same goal file each run, one task per iteration.

Memory lives in files and git, not in context.

G. HUNTLEY

FEB 2026

02

AGENTIC ENG.

Successor to vibe coding. You orchestrate agents and keep oversight.

Engineering is a skill you can learn.

A. KARPATHY

MAR 2026

03

HARNESS

Planner, generator, evaluator. A sprint contract defines "done" before any code exists.

Agents grade their own work too kindly.

ANTHROPIC

2026

04

/GOAL

Set a completion condition. After every turn a separate model checks it. Built on a Stop hook, built into Claude Code.

CLAUDE CODE

GOOD CONDITION "All tests in test/auth pass, lint is clean"

NOT CHECKABLE "The app is production-ready"

LEVEL 05 · ORCHESTRATION

One agent builds. Another judges.

Separate roles, agreed criteria, state in files and git.

